CAREER GLITCH · SHORT · SIMPLE · NO BORING PARTS

TECHNICAL WRITER IN THE AI ERA

AI writes the manual now. The job left is teaching the machine — or leaving the page.

★ TL;DR — NO. The pay is genuinely good — ~$90K median (BLS $90,390) — but the door is closing: BLS projects +1% growth over a decade, about +400 net jobs, and warns in its own text that AI tools may slow even that. The roadmap below is the way OUT, not in. ★

THE CAREER GLITCH TAKE

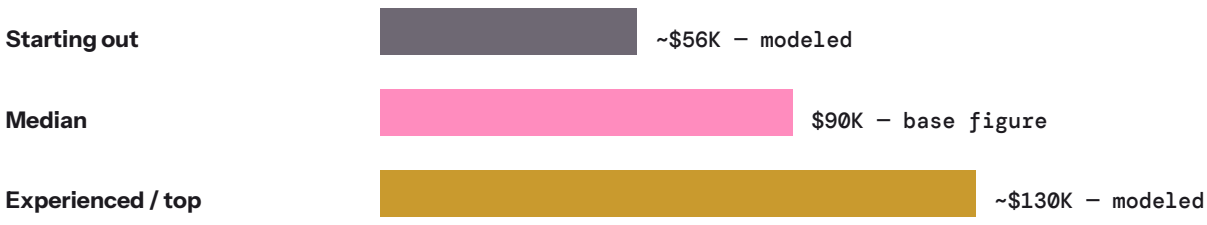
OUR TAKE: NO — NOT IN 2027

MEDIAN ~$90K · TRAINING 6-12 months · AI RISK HIGH · CERTIFICATE

- Fails as a start because: +1% growth means almost no new seats — a beginner competes for replacement openings against experienced writers, and the entry-level work (docs, help centers, release notes) is the first thing teams hand to AI.
- The money is NOT the problem: a ~$90K median with the top 10% over $145K. The insiders are fine — it's the entrance that's frozen.
- Still worth money: your ability to understand a complex system and explain it. That skill sells in UX and automation, not in documents.

The site's take, built from this profession's numbers in the Career Glitch base.

THE MONEY — LOOK AT THE BARS



The Career Glitch base figure for Technical Writer is a ~$90K median (compiled from U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook ranges). The starting and top bars are modeled around that median — orientation, not a promise. Pay swings hard by state, employer and experience: check live postings in your state before planning around any number.

WHAT DOES A TECHNICAL WRITER ACTUALLY DO?

- ✓ Interview engineers and turn product specs into manuals, guides and help-center articles
- ✓ Maintain documentation libraries as the product changes every release
- ✓ Test the product yourself to find the steps the engineers forgot to mention
- ✓ Rewrite dense technical material so a non-technical user survives it

Think: a translator between engineers and everyone else — except the new translator is software and works for free.

WHAT AI ALREADY TOOK (AND WHAT IT CAN'T)

THE ROBOT	THE HUMAN
Drafting standard documentation, API references, release notes, style cleanup, doc translation — LLMs produce all of it in minutes, good enough for most help centers.	Figuring out what is actually true in a messy system, interviewing experts, information-architecture judgment, and deciding what a confused user needs first. That judgment is the part that transfers.

⚠ **THE CERTIFICATE TRAP: docs certificates still sell the 2019 job. The 2027 posting says 'AI tools experience required' — because the tool does the writing.**

THE VIBE — IS THIS YOUR LIFE?

THE JOB IS	THE JOB IS NOT
✓ Quiet, remote, deadline-driven — a writer's life without the byline ✓ Deep focus work, few meetings, your calendar is mostly yours ✓ You become the person who actually understands how the product works	✗ Not stable: documentation teams are cut early in every layoff round ✗ Not growing: each AI release deletes another slice of the task list ✗ Not respected: the docs are 'nice to have' until the budget meeting

Good fit? Already a technical writer with deep domain knowledge — medical devices, aviation, regulated industries. Your niche knowledge, not the writing, is the moat.
Bad fit? Beginners picking it as a safe desk job. Safe is the one thing it stopped being.

THE FORK — PICK ONE DOOR

DOOR A — PIVOT TO UX/UI Designer	DOOR B — PIVOT TO AI Automation Specialist

A $99,520 median with +5% growth (BLS, Web Developers and Digital Designers) — and UX writing / content design is the classic technical-writer migration. You already do the core work: take a confusing flow and make it survivable. Here it happens inside the product, in screens and states, with real entry-level seats. First move: take one help-center flow you documented and redesign it as an in-product UX flow — screens, error states, microcopy. That's your portfolio piece.	No official number exists for this job — BLS doesn't track the title, so the ~$120K figures quoted for it are market talk, not a statistic. The overlap is real, though: you stop documenting workflows and start automating them, and nobody reads a 40-step SOP better than the person who used to write them. First move: pick one painful manual process at any small company and automate it end to end — that's the demo that sells the service.

Smart move: If you're already in: become the person who owns the AI docs pipeline — prompts, review, quality gates. The writer who runs the machine keeps a job; the writer competing with it doesn't.

Where you land after: You land in UX or automation — same brain, same systems knowledge, work AI assists instead of replaces.

YOUR ROADMAP — 6 STEPS

1	2	3	4	5	6
STOP POLISHING	LEARN HOW	REDESIGN ONE	ADD THE	APPLY SIDEWAYS,	INTERVIEW LIKE

STEP 1 — Stop polishing the docs portfolio

FREE · TODAY

- Delete 'technical writer' as the target title — the search is over
- List the 3 products you understand deeply; that knowledge is your capital

STEP 2 — Learn how UX thinks

FREE · 1–2 WEEKS

- Content design, UX writing, flows and states, research basics
- Map every docs task you did to the UX task it secretly was

STEP 3 — Redesign one real flow

FREE · 2 WEEKS

- Take a help flow you documented; rebuild it as in-product UX
- Show the screens, the error states and the microcopy — that artifact is your portfolio

STEP 4 — Add the automation string

SELF-PACED · 3–4 WEEKS

- Automate one real workflow with an AI builder/agent tool
- Write it up as a case study: before, after, time saved

STEP 5 — Apply sideways, not down

FREE · ONGOING

- Target UX/UI designer and automation roles at companies whose products you can already explain
- Lead every application with the redesign and the case study, not the docs clips

STEP 6 — Interview like an insider

FREE · ONGOING

- Talk about user confusion you've personally watched — UX teams hire that scar tissue
- Ask about their docs; then explain how you'd move them into the product

FIRST 90 DAYS — JUST DO THIS

□ Today: write down the verdict — no new docs courses, no portfolio polish. The exit plan starts now.

□ Days 1–30: UX and content-design fundamentals daily; finish the flow redesign.

□ Days 31–60: build and document one AI automation; start applying to UX and automation roles.

□ Days 61–90: interview loop running; ship a second redesign or automation from a target company's product.

□ Day 90: you are a UX/automation candidate with artifacts — not a writer waiting at a frozen door.

NEXT — MAKE IT PERSONAL

This roadmap is the same for everyone. Your life is not.

- Not sure this career fits YOU? Take the Big Career Test — 50 questions, your top-3 matches and one honest “probably NOT you”. → careerglitch.com/#test
- Already sure? Turn AI into Your Personal Career Mentor — a 2,300-word system that interviews you first, checks your hours, budget and deadline honestly, and builds YOUR plan into a Notion dashboard. → careerglitch.com/#prompt

★ DON'T COMPETE WITH THE TOOL. OWN IT. ★